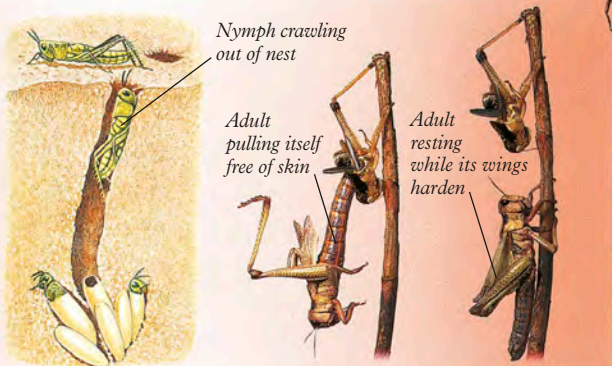


Growing up

Female locusts lay their eggs in the sand. The babies, called nymphs, hatch and dig their way out. When they appear, they are tiny versions of their parents. In order to become fully grown adults, the nymphs molt between three and five times. After each molt the nymphs are bigger than before. When they molt for the final time, they emerge with full-sized wings.



Nymph crawling out of nest

Adult pulling itself free of skin

Adult resting while its wings harden

The trouble with locusts

When heavy rains fall in hot, dry regions, lush plant life begins to grow. With lots of food, large numbers of grasshoppers get together to mate. After mating, they eat all the plant life around them and grow much larger. In search of more food, they take to the air in huge swarms, devouring fields of valuable crops.



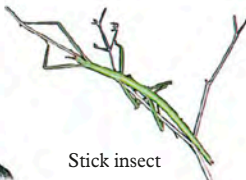
Locust-infested areas

Extended family

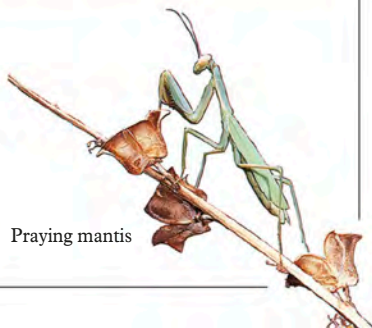
All of these insects are related to grasshoppers but they have quite different features—and very clever disguises.



Leaf insect



Stick insect



Praying mantis